Q+A

PUNCHING ABOVE HER WEIGHT

With an Olympic bronze in her kitty, **Lovlina Borgohain** recently won a gold medal at the Asian Elite Boxing Championships in Amman. Competing in a new weight category, she seems ready for every new challenge

Q. You faced criticism about your performance post the Tokyo Olympics. Did it get you down?
I felt bad, but the truth is that I was struggling with form and I was unable to focus on training. I also had to change my weight category from 69 to 75 kg [as the 69 kg division was not included in Paris 2024] and that took time to adjust to. I tried to take [the criticism] positively. It's only when the going gets tough that you grow and learn.

Q. Competing in a new weight category isn't easy...
It's easier to reduce weight and compete. Boxers in a higher weight category have more strength and therefore, the power of their punch is that much more. Also, when your body becomes heavier, your speed is affected, you get tired quicker and there are nutrition changes, too.

Q. Has winning gold helped boost your morale?
I gained a lot of confidence. My previous two competitions weren't that great. I just have two years to qualify for the Olympics and every tournament matters for preparation. Post the Olympics, the expectations are that much more, and being both calm and patient is important.

Q. How much has life changed post Tokyo?
Earlier, people didn't know about us. Now, you must be very conscious of what you do. Going to public places is also harder. Everybody is watching, so you can't do some things freely.

Q. What's your target for 2023?
The aim is to do well in each competition. The World Championship will be held in New Delhi next year, so that is a great opportunity to excel. The Asian Games are also very important.

with Suhani Singh

Now a middleweight, the boxer is prepping for the World Championship and Asian Games scheduled in 2023

GETTY IMAGES